



Photograph by BIJU GOPAL

GENTLE RETREAT
(clockwise from far left) Living room by Lumber & Yarn Homes; Mustard Design Studio uses modern design with classic material here; the vernacular becomes cool in this verandah by Sunya Creative; dining space by Syzygy Designs



Let the Eyes Rest

A sense of calm often begins with what the eye doesn't have to process. Visual restraint has become just as important as visual expression, with designers favouring cohesive palettes over competing focal points.

"We often think that a home feels complete only when every wall is decorated and every surface is styled," says Banu Sundar, founder of Studio Couch Potato. "But I have always found the opposite to be true. Leaving a little breathing room allows the eye to settle and the mind to slow down." In spaces where every element has a reason to exist, the mind expends less energy making sense of its surroundings.

Nature Beyond Greenery

Houseplants are only one expression of biophilic design. Natural light, cross ventilation, filtered views and materials that age gracefully reconnect us with natural rhythms often lost in screen-filled lives.

Architectural academic and theorist Dr. Anuradha Chatterjee, from RV University, believes these everyday encounters are restorative. "The presence of life, simplicity of natural and ethically sourced materials, and the changing daylight with the changing season, create spaces that calm, nurture and regenerate us," she says.

Quiet Isn't the Absence of Sound

The experience of a room is shaped as much by what we hear as what we see. Hard floors and bare walls look sharp in photographs and sound sharper in real life, as they amplify echoes and everyday noise.

Acoustic softening—through rugs, heavy drapery, upholstered furniture—is design's quietest form of care. The goal isn't silence, but a quieter backdrop that makes conversations, reading or simply unwinding feel noticeably more comfortable.

The New Personal

A shift is already underway. China's For-me-ism movement champions homes conceived around the people who inhabit them, privileging individual routines above aesthetic trends.

For Ananya Jois, principal architect at Jois Design House, this philosophy has always been central to good design. "The most calming homes aren't necessarily the most minimal—they're the most intuitive," she says. Her process begins with understanding how clients actually live before discussing materials or finishes. "When a home solves everyday problems before they arise, it naturally feels calm," she adds.

Jayashree Jain, who helms Vivante Design Studio, highlights an invisible sensory layer—the scents. "The most memorable homes embrace the comforting aromas of everyday rituals—fresh flowers, brewed coffee or a favourite meal simmering on the stove," she shares.

None of this asks anyone to give something up. Micro-moments of calm emerge through small, intentional decisions that transform how a home feels. The conversation between body and space has always existed; thoughtful design simply teaches us to listen.

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